

up with a more audacious plan. The US should enter into a deal that promised full civilian nuclear power co-operation with India. That included an ability to trade in nuclear power equipment and also reprocess fuel. The US should agree to amend its domestic laws and also get the Nuclear Suppliers Group (NSG) to lift the ban on conducting nuclear trade with India. On its part, India would separate its civilian and military nuclear facilities in a phased manner and put those reactors it designated as civilian under International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) safeguards.

It was a win-win for both sides. America's interest had shifted to Asia and it was looking at India as a coun-

in the globalised world, "improving relations with the US was key". India was entering second generation of industrialisation which the technology denial regime would largely undermine.

The July 18, 2005 agreement which set up the deal went down to the wire with an agreement being reached just an hour before the two leaders announced it. Bush had told Manmohan the previous evening, "Don't think I would help you in making bombs." Manmohan's concern was that the deal shouldn't in anyway hinder India's nuclear weapons programme. So when Secretary of State Condoleezza Rice met him the next

find favour among its leaders. Manmohan says he was stunned by their hostility and even sent a word to Vajpayee through an emissary asking, "Why are you jeopardising the deal?"

The next major milestone on the deal would have to wait till Bush paid his first visit to India in March 2006. To avoid giving away too much, Manmohan announced in Parliament a separation plan designating 14 of India's 22 power reactors as civilian. But in return for putting them under IAEA safeguards in perpetuity, India sought cast-iron guarantees that fuel supply to them would be uninterrupted. There was to be no scope for repetition of a Tarapur like incident.

When US officials balked, Bush intervened and conceded India's demand.

The two sides believed that the going would be much easier after that. But they underestimated the strength of the US non-proliferation lobby and the concerns Congressmen had, over dismantling the nuclear architecture by making an exception for India. Or that the



tervailing force to China. With its economy growing at an impressive 8 per cent, India was also an attractive market. Bush had always been keen on improving relations with India telling his advisers, "You can't ignore a one-billion-strong democracy. We have to find ways of engaging with it."

For India, as Manmohan says, energy security was a key to becoming a world power and sustaining its economic strength. A deal would enable it to boost its nuclear power production that currently contributes an abysmal 3 per cent to the country's total electricity needs. When he came to power, Manmohan had a foreign policy review carried out and the conclusion was that

LAST-MINUTE PUSH: Indian negotiators with their US counterparts

morning, Manmohan made it clear to her that "India can't agree to a bilateral NPT or CTBT". There would be no deal unless some of the offending provisions were dropped. Rice spoke to Bush soon after and he agreed to do it. The deal legitimised India's status as a nuclear weapons power ending its isolation.

When Manmohan returned to India, he thought the BJP would endorse the deal. After all, unlike the Left, he believed that BJP was committed to improving relations with the US. And also, since the NDA government led by A.B. Vajpayee had initiated the NSSP and had offered such a deal in the past, it would

Republicans would soon lose their majority in both the Houses. It would take plenty of persuasion from Bush's team and lobbying by India to stop killer amendments to the Congressional bill waiving clauses in the existing law that prevented trade with India. The Hyde Act had most of the offensive statements in its non-binding sections but still had enough to "dampen" the agreement, as National Security Adviser M.K. Narayanan puts it.

In India, both Left and BJP accused Manmohan of being taken to the cleaners. Even Anil Kakodkar, the Atomic Energy Commission chief, complained that the US was changing goalposts. Under pressure, Manmohan would ad-

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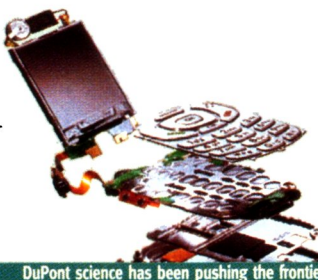
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